

Week 31: Doubt

BIG IDEA

The speaker walked away from Christianity in high school because his doubts were met with 'just believe.' Students will face doubt too, and unanswered doubts are one reason so many leave youth group after high school. Invite doubts openly and walk with students through them; God can handle any question.

KEY POINTS FROM THE LEADER VIDEO

- The speaker left Christianity as a high school student because he had questions and doubts and was told not to ask them, just to have faith.
- Statistics still show a large majority of students leave youth group after high school, and unanswered doubts are one reason why.
- More information often brings more questions, so keep the group an open, authentic forum that invites the difficult questions, and share your own doubts.
- Helping students navigate doubt actually furthers their faith; expressing doubts freely shows them leaders understand, have been there, and will walk with them.
- The intro activity has each student write down one question they are wrestling with; a Q&A session lets one student's question answer another's unspoken one.
- Make sure small group leaders are equipped, know it is okay to say 'I don't have an answer,' and use a storyteller who has walked through doubt.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What is one question about God or faith you have been wrestling with?
2. Have you ever felt you were not allowed to ask a question about faith? What happened?
3. Why do you think doubts, when answered honestly, can actually make faith stronger?
4. Who could you talk to when a doubt feels bigger than you can handle alone?

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LEADER VIDEO — FULL TRANSCRIPT

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Why I walked away

0:05 Years ago, when I was a high school student, I walked away from Christianity and went down a whole other path for a good long time. The primary reason I walked away is that I had questions and I had doubts. You have gotten up to this point now where you not only have all this content — we've talked about love, we've talked about the power of questions and the power of conversation — but somewhere in there, at some point, questions from others, information from other people, going to college, all kinds of different things are going to come at your students, causing doubt. What happens when they doubt?

0:54 I walked away because I was doubting. I asked a question, and I was told not to ask the questions. I was told to just believe. I was told to just have faith, and I didn't even know what that meant. I couldn't figure it all out, so I said enough, and I walked away. The statistics are still out there, and they're still pretty prevalent, that a large majority of students leave youth group after high school. There are a whole bunch of reasons for that. One of them is that when they have doubts, those doubts aren't getting answered.

Invite the doubts in

1:36 So this is an opportunity to open it up to your students and say, "Listen, I get it. I know you have doubts." Maybe share some of your own — and that's okay. Let's talk about it. Let's make sure this is an open forum. Weeks ago, at the very beginning of this process, we talked about the idea of having open communication and having a youth group that was very authentic and very open and invited the difficult questions. We talked about how those difficult questions were going to come. They're probably going to come even more now, because sometimes the more information you have, the more questions you have as a result.

2:14 So invite those in. Invite those doubts — whether students are not sure about Jesus, not sure about the existence of God, not sure about the biblical text, not sure about evil and pain and suffering, not sure about any of the things we've talked about, and maybe some things we haven't talked about, because there are a whole bunch of cultural issues that step into this that you have to help students navigate.

2:36 And that's where helping students navigate doubt is an incredibly important thing, an important tool at actually furthering their faith. Because as they get those things answered, as they feel free to express those doubts, that tells them that we as leaders understand, that we've been there, that it's okay, and that we're going to walk with them through those.

Large group Q&A

3:01 So for the introduction activity this week, we asked students literally to write down one question they've been wrestling with. Now, as a large group activity, you might actually take and compile some of those. You might do a Q&A session. I find Q&A sessions to be incredibly helpful. I open up the floor to students and just let them ask whatever they want.

3:24 And yes, you get some funny ones. I get a lot of dinosaur questions, and some interesting ones about Adam and Eve, and those can be fun. You can play around with those a little bit and have some fun with it. But at the same time, some really good and profound questions will come up, and the advantage to that is that if one student asks a question and another student is afraid to ask that same question, the student who was afraid gets their question answered. That can be an incredibly important and powerful tool.

Prepare your small group leaders

3:55 So I would encourage you to maybe do that this week, or to find a way to incorporate many questions into your large group time. Then, during small group time, you can drill those questions down a little bit deeper. But make sure, as you do that, that your small group leaders are adequately prepared to handle some of the questions. Based on your situation and the leadership you have in place and the volunteers you have in place, just make sure that they are equipped to properly answer. And remind them that it's okay if they don't have an answer — to say, "I don't have an answer," and to write those questions down, bring them back, and find a way to get those questions answered specifically.

This week's storyteller

4:38 Another important, powerful tool is your storyteller this week. To have somebody in front of your students who has actually expressed that out loud and walked through it in some way, shape or form can be incredibly important. That story, whatever they've been through, will resonate, I'm sure, with many of your students. So make sure you know that you don't need to find the best story or the biggest story or the most compelling story — just something that lets students see, "Hey, I'm not the only one going through this. I'm not the only student dealing with this. I'm not the only person who has ever dealt with this, and people have gotten through it."

God can handle it

5:16 Because some students might just have little questions here and there. Other students might be at a significant crisis of faith in their lives, where they need serious direction. And after all that you've gone through in this study, some of those things may start to come up to the surface a little bit. So remind your students that no matter their questions, no matter their doubts, God can handle it, and that He has given us everything we need to be entirely confident of who He is, who Jesus is, and what our salvation means.